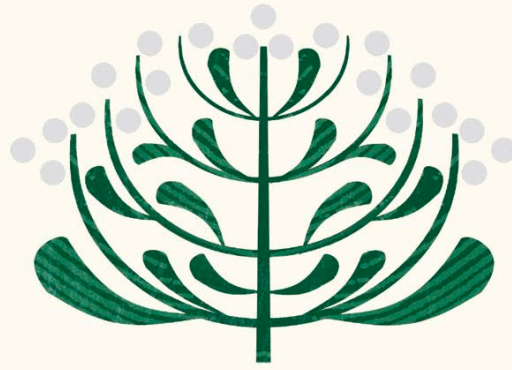




Now it is time for the sad story of Baldr the Bright, son of Odin and Frigg, the most joyful, beloved and generous of the Aesir gods.

“I had a terrible dream last night,” Baldr told his parents one morning. “I saw a ship at sea beneath a sky filled with crows. And I was lying on the deck – cold, stiff... and dead.”

Odin and Frigg were afraid. They believed that dreams could be visions of the future, and they knew their son’s death foreshadowed Ragnarök – the doomed destiny of the gods.

So Odin travelled to visit a seer in Niflheim – the icy world of the dead – to discover what the awful dream might mean. Here he entered a drinking hall adorned with rich red cloth and hung with gold. At the end of the hall stood the seer. She told Odin that they were getting ready to celebrate the death of Baldr.

*“He’s to be our guest of honour,
and we dead cannot wait to meet him,” she said.*

Odin returned to Asgard to tell Frigg the terrible news.

“Our beautiful son will soon be dead, and Ragnarök will crash down upon us afterwards.”

Frigg straightened her back. “Not on my watch,” she said.